with regards to return to office and the feedback from our employees has been very positive," says Shaji Mathew, group head, human resource development, Infosys.

Gen Z has also pushed companies across the world to focus more—and rightly so—on mental and emotional well-being initiatives. At the beauty and wellness firm Marico Limited, for instance, onsite workshops and counselling sessions have become a regular feature. "We realised that with changing times and business priorities, the aspirations of the future workforce are evolving as well," says Amit Prakash, chief human resources officer at Marico. "We have, therefore, established the right platforms to encourage and support open discussions around it. We have also introduced the '1to1' mobile application that serves as an exclusive emotional wellness platform for our members." On the other end there are pet-friendly workplaces that let employees get their pets to office—something that has been known to improve employee well-being. For instance, at the offices of the petcare chain Heads Up For Tails, it's not uncommon to find the workplace stocked with water bowls, chew toys and mats to keep employees' pets engaged. "We firmly believe that every home and workplace should exude the warmth and joy that pets bring," says Rashi Narang, the founder and CEO of the chain.

"Today's young workforce is deeply committed to working for organisations that share their values. In India, 88 per cent professionals prefer companies that not only talk the talk but walk the talk when it comes to fostering a work culture that values sustainability, diversity, and inclusiveness," says Susan Mathew, HR director at LinkedIn India. "Many young professionals are also open to non-linear career paths, making skill development and learning opportunities critical factors in their employment choices. They value a balanced office environment that offers spaces for both collaboration and individual focus. Amenities that support this, such as communal areas for networking and private quiet rooms for concentrating, are highly appreciated."

Research also underlines the benefits of taking time off. The landmark Framingham Heart Study, the largest and longest-running study of cardiovascular diseases, shows that men who didn't take a vacation for several years were 30 per cent more likely to have heart attacks, and women who took one only once every six years or less were almost eight times more likely to develop cardiovascular issues.

To the world, it may seem Gen Z is being impractical, or asking for a lot. Except, they are not. Singh of Mondelez India sums it up well. "The skills that they can learn," she says, "are more important than the hierarchy they operate at. For them, every job of today has to build their prospects for tomorrow." That, in a sense, is as much a journey for today's workplaces to make as for the ever-independent Gen Zers, who refuse to be wrung dry by a nine-to-five existence. ■

(With inputs from Sonal Khetarpal and M.G. Arun)

ADVAIT THAKUR, 20 ▼

Founder, Apex Infosys India, Mumbai

Thakur decided to start his own tech firm at the age of 15. Today, his company specialises in smart home systems that automate devices such as lights, audio, security, etc. Thakur was nervous about starting his own venture, but what helped him take the leap, he says, was creating the right environment. "I focused on the bigger picture. I surrounded myself with mentors and like-minded people who believed in my vision. Their guidance helped me navigate the initial hurdles," he says. Thakur loves being his own boss. "While the service sector offers stability and a structured environment, having my own company has allowed me to pursue my creative ideas and chart my own path," he says.

MILIND SHELTE

